HYBRID WORK

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Hybrid Work Video • Flexibility Resource Sheet • Running Hybrid Meetings Resource Sheet
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Understand best practices of leading in a hybrid environment. • Understand the challenges of structure, individuals and culture in hybrid work. • Analyze how and when to apply flexibility and rigidity in decision making. • Analyze best practices associated with running a hybrid meeting. • Evaluate different meeting agenda techniques to determine best practices for creating a meeting
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 40 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

In the contemporary work landscape, the hybrid environment has become a norm, blending the traditional office setting with the flexibility of remote work. This model presents unique challenges and opportunities, making it imperative for leaders to adopt best practices specifically tailored to this novel paradigm. Effective leadership in a hybrid environment demands a nuanced approach that transcends conventional management tactics, ensuring that both remote and in-office team members are engaged, productive, and cohesive. Leaders must cultivate a deep understanding of the dynamics at play in hybrid settings, where the equilibrium between flexibility and structure, autonomy and accountability, as well as digital and physical presence, is crucial.

Adapting to best practices in a hybrid setup involves fostering clear communication, ensuring equitable inclusion, and maintaining a strong sense of community. Leaders are tasked with creating an environment where all team members, regardless of their physical location, feel valued, heard, and fully integrated into the team. This requires intentional strategies to bridge the physical divide, such as running best practice hybrid meetings that achieve both stronger relationships between team members and accomplish team goals. Moreover, leaders must champion a culture of trust and transparency, where outcomes are prioritized over visibility, thereby empowering individuals to deliver their best work. Embracing these best practices not only enhances team effectiveness and satisfaction but also positions the organization to thrive in the evolving world of work, harnessing the full potential of its diverse workforce.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This "pair and share" technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the "pair and share" method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then have those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the who group.

Leading in a Hybrid Environment General Questions

The following questions are based on the Leading in Hybrid Environment video:

1. In general, what has been your experience leading a hybrid work environment? What have been the positives of a hybrid work environment? What have been your biggest challenges when leading in a hybrid work environment?
2. Have you established expectations, with individuals on your team, discussing how often you should communicate? How often do you communicate? What is covered in the communication? Have you established expectations on how you will hold individuals on your team accountable? What has worked well when establishing these expectations? What issues have you had when setting up these expectations?

3. What does it mean to have a “results driven mindset?” Can you provide an example of a time over the past month when you have had a results driven mindset with an individual on your team? What are some of the challenges you are facing having a results driven mindset to hold individuals accountable?
4. Jot down three names of individuals on your team. Next to their name, write down how you think they would respond to the question, “How are you managing your work-life balance?” Next, what was the last personal/professional development activity they engaged in? How difficult was it to determine work-life balance and development of your team? How can you keep better track of how they are doing in both areas? (After the training follow up with the employees to see if you were right!)
5. How has the culture of your team/organization changed since moving to hybrid work? How are you establishing connection between individuals on your team? What has worked really well for you when building a team culture? Are there any unique practices you do with your team that help to build your culture?

Additional Activity on Leading in Hybrid Environments:

1. Self-Assessment: Utilize the “**Scenarios or Challenges that are Commonly Encountered in Hybrid Work Settings”** sheet provided below. Have the participants role play each issue, taking turns playing both the leader and the employee raising the scenario or challenge. After each role play, bring participants back together as a group to discuss what worked and what issues emerged. Then move on to the next scenario or challenge and repeat the process.

Power of Flexibility in Hybrid Work Questions

The following questions are based on the Utilizing the Benefits of Flexibility in Hybrid Work Best Practice Article:

1. Think of a time over the last week:
   a. When a situation required you to ask for feedback and collaboration from others. How were you able to utilize this feedback or suggestion to move forward with a decision? How did you use the power of flexibility to take others feedback or suggestions into account? Was it the right decision (or action)?
   b. When a situation required you to take decisive action. What was it about the situation that lead you to taking decisive action rather than asking for feedback and collaboration in making the decision (or taking action). Was it the right decision (or action)?
2. Without naming names, are their people on your team you are more likely to be flexible with when it comes to making decisions? What is it about these individuals that allows you to utilize flexibility? What is it about others on the team that requires less flexibility when you are leading them or make decisions about them? In your opinion, is treating employees or teams differently, when it comes to utilizing flexibility, an issue or effective leadership?

3. What is your bias toward flexibility? Would you consider yourself a more flexible or more rigid leader? How do you think others view you based on your willingness to use flexibility or stick to a more rigid style of leadership?
4. Looking at the core values of the organization, do you think the values favor utilizing flexibility or being more rigid? On an organizational level, how is being flexible or rigid reinforced in the organization?
5. Think of a leader in your organization who is more flexible and one who is more rigid. When these leaders are at their best and most effective, how do they utilize being flexible/rigid to be an effective leader?
6. Which of the twelve best practices (from the article) most resonated with you? Which one do you think would have the greatest impact on your leadership if you put it into practice? How would you go about demonstrating that best practice more often?

Additional Flexibility Leadership Activity:

1. Self-Assessment: During the workshop provide participants with the flexibility self-assessment questionnaire provided. Encourage them to reflect on their current flexibility habits, strengths, and areas for improvement. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas of flexible leadership. Get participants into pairs and ask them to share their score, what they believe it means about their leadership, and one possible action they can take to become a more flexible leader.
2. "Yes…And" Exercise: Incorporate the "Yes, And" improv exercise into your training regimen to cultivate flexibility and enhance collaborative skills among leaders. This exercise, rooted in improvisational theater, encourages participants to build on each other's ideas without judgment, fostering an environment of open-mindedness and rapid adaptability. When conducting this exercise, leaders will pair up or work in small groups, where one person begins with a statement or idea (can be from a problem identified by the group or trainer), and the other responds by accepting the premise ("Yes") and then expanding on it ("And"). This practice not only bolsters creative problem-solving and effective communication but also promotes a culture of affirmation and mutual support, essential qualities for dynamic and flexible leadership. By engaging in "Yes, And" regularly, leaders learn to navigate uncertainty, adapt to evolving situations, and co-create innovative solutions, all while maintaining a positive and inclusive team dynamic.

Hybrid Meeting Questions

The following questions are based on the Hybrid Meeting Article:

1. Take a minute to reflect on the meetings you have attended in the last week (this is an overall reflection). On a scale **1** (not great meetings; did not use best practices; felt like a waste of time) to **10** (best meetings; utilized best practices; we got so much accomplished) think about where you would rate them on the scale. Once you have a number, and don't worry where it falls, talk with your partner about why you rated the meetings this way. Based on the article, what could change in those meetings that would move them up a point or two on the scale.

2. Take a few minutes to complete the same rating scale, however, this time only consider the meetings you have lead over the past week (or two). How do you think participants in those meetings would rate your meetings?
3. After reading the article, which of the best practice hybrid meeting techniques have you used in the past? Did you find them helpful in running an effective meeting? Why or why not?
4. Which of the best practice hybrid meeting techniques have you NOT used in the past? What has stopped you from utilizing them in your meeting set-up or execution? If you were to pick one of the best practices you have not used in the past and started using it, which one would you select? How do you think it would have a positive impact on your meetings or your leadership?
5. Are there any hybrid meeting (or regular meeting) best practice techniques that you have used (and have been successful for you) that are not included in the article? Take a few minutes out, pair up and share them with a partner. Then share with the entire group.

Additional Hybrid Meeting Activity:

1. Examining Meeting Agendas: Ask participants to Look at the two agendas provided below (one at a time - Example A & Example B). After looking over the agenda, work in groups of two to figure out what the agenda is missing and how to address the issue. With the whole class, ask participants what issues were identified with the agenda (Answers for facilitator are provided after agenda example - do not pass out to participants). Once the group has discussed Agenda Example A move on to Agenda Example B.

Scenarios or Challenges that are Commonly Encountered in Hybrid Work Settings:

- **Communication Breakdown: A crucial update shared during an in-office meeting was not properly communicated to remote team members, leading to confusion and delays in project timelines.**

- **Tech Troubles: During a key decision-making meeting, the remote team members face persistent technical issues, preventing them from participating effectively, while in-office members proceed with the discussion.**

- **Exclusion from Spontaneous Conversations: Remote employees miss out on impromptu brainstorming sessions that happen in the office, resulting in a lack of input on important projects and feeling out of the loop.**

- **Scheduling Conflicts: A recurring team meeting is scheduled at a time that suits in-office workers but consistently conflicts with the working hours or previously scheduled commitments of remote team members.**

- **Overlooked Contributions: In a hybrid meeting, contributions from remote participants are inadvertently overlooked, with in-office employees dominating the conversation and decision-making process.**

- **Access to Information: Important documents and resources are frequently shared physically in the office but not uploaded to shared digital platforms, making them inaccessible to remote workers.**

- **Team Bonding Disparities: The office organizes team-building activities that cater primarily to in-person staff, leaving remote members feeling excluded and disconnected from the team culture.**

- **Feedback and Recognition Imbalance: Remote employees feel that their achievements are less visible compared to their in-office counterparts, impacting their motivation and opportunities for recognition or advancement.**

- **Unequal Access to Leadership: Remote team members find it challenging to secure one-on-one time with leadership, whereas in-office employees have more opportunities for face-to-face interactions and spontaneous conversations with managers.**

- **Inconsistent Policy Application: Company policies regarding work hours, availability, and responsiveness are applied inconsistently, with remote workers often expected to be more accessible outside of standard work hours compared to their in-office colleagues.**

Leader Flexibility Self Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

1. I quickly adapt my leadership style when a situation changes unexpectedly.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I am open to trying new approaches when solving problems.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I actively seek feedback to improve my flexibility as a leader.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I feel comfortable making decisions in ambiguous or uncertain situations.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I encourage innovation and creativity within my team, even at the risk of failure.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I am willing to revise my plans based on new information or feedback.

1 2 3 4 5

7. I can effectively manage and lead through periods of significant change.

1 2 3 4 5

8. I value diverse perspectives and consider them in my decision-making process.

1 2 3 4 5

9. I can balance the need for organizational structure with the need for flexibility.

1 2 3 4 5

10. I am adept at shifting priorities quickly in response to the needs of my team or organization.

1 2 3 4 5

11. I maintain a positive attitude in the face of change and encourage my team to do the same.

1 2 3 4 5

12. I am open to delegating tasks and authority when situational demands change.

1 2 3 4 5

13. I actively promote a culture where learning from mistakes is viewed as an opportunity for growth.

1 2 3 4 5

14. I readily explore alternative solutions when faced with obstacles.

1 2 3 4 5

15. My decision-making process is fluid and adapts to new challenges and information.

1 2 3 4 5

16. I frequently reassess organizational processes and am open to redesigning them for better efficiency.

1 2 3 4 5

17. I can effectively communicate changes in plans or strategy to my team in a way that gains their support.

1 2 3 4 5

18. I recognize when traditional methods are not working and am quick to explore innovative solutions.

1 2 3 4 5

19. I am skilled at balancing my own leadership convictions with the flexibility to incorporate new ideas.

1 2 3 4 5

20. I view unexpected challenges as opportunities to learn and grow, rather than as setbacks.

1 2 3 4 5

Scoring: Calculate your total score by adding up the ratings for each statement. A higher score indicates stronger Flexibility Leadership skills and habits.

Total Score: _____

Interpretation:

- 81-100: **Exceptional Flexibility** - You excel in adapting to new situations and leading through change. Keep leveraging your strengths in flexibility while mentoring others to develop their adaptability skills
- 61-80: **High Flexibility** - You are quite adaptable, yet there’s always space to grow. Continue to nurture your ability to adjust swiftly and effectively to new circumstances while fostering a culture of flexibility within your team.
- 41-60: **Moderate Flexibility** - You show some adaptability but there's room for improvement. Focus on enhancing your response to change, seeking diverse perspectives, and cultivating an environment that values agile decision-making.
- Below 40: **Low Flexibility** - You may struggle to adapt to change and could benefit from developing strategies to become more open to new experiences, feedback, and altering your approach based on situational demands

Example A

Agenda

Meeting Title: Quarterly Sales Review
Date: September 15, 2023
Time: 9:00 AM - 11:00 AM
Location: Conference Room B / Virtual Link: www.zoom.com
Attendees: All Sales Team Members, Sales Manager, Marketing Coordinator, Product Development Lead

Meeting:

1. **Sales Performance Review**
   - Look at sales figures
   - Discuss challenges and successes
2. **Client Feedback Overview**
   - Share some client feedback
3. **New Market Strategies**
   - Brainstorming session
4. **Product Updates**
   - Quick update on upcoming products
5. **Miscellaneous**
   - Any other business

Example A: Feedback
Facilitator's Notes

Issues with the Agenda:

- Tone: The meeting does not start out with a purposeful or intentional tone (Recognition).
- Lack of Specificity: The agenda items are vague and do not clearly define what will be discussed or what needs to be achieved.
- No Time Allocations: There are no specific time slots assigned to each agenda item, making it difficult to manage time effectively during the meeting.
- Undefined Objectives: The agenda does not articulate clear objectives or desired outcomes for the meeting or its individual segments.
- Missing Details: It lacks details such as who is responsible for leading each discussion point. Also, no time-keeper or notes taker established.

Example B

Date: October 10, 2023
Time: 1:00 PM - 4:00 PM
Location: Virtual Meeting Room
Attendees: Marketing Team, Product Managers, External Consultants

Agenda:

1. **Review of Past Year's Marketing Campaigns**
   - Discussion on what was done last year.
2. **Brainstorming Future Campaigns**
   - Think about ideas for next year.
3. **Budget Considerations**
   - How much can we spend?
4. **Role Assignments**
   - Who will do what?
5. **Open Floor**
   - Any other points to discuss.

Example B: Feedback
Facilitator's Notes

Issues with the Provided Agenda:

1. Ambiguous Agenda Items: The agenda points are extremely vague, such as "Discussion on what was done last year" or "Think about ideas for next year," which do not provide clear guidance on the specific topics to be covered or the scope of the discussion. Also, no link provided for attendees.
2. Lack of Specific Objectives: There are no defined objectives or expected outcomes for the meeting or individual agenda items. Attendees are left unsure about the purpose of the meeting and what needs to be achieved.
3. Missing Time Allocations: The agenda does not specify how much time is allocated for each item. Without this, there's a risk that some sections may overrun while others are rushed or skipped entirely.
4. Absence of Detail on Budget Discussion: "How much can we spend?" is an overly simplified representation of what should be a detailed financial discussion, lacking the necessary specifics to prepare attendees for a productive conversation.
5. Vague Role Assignments: "Who will do what?" is too broad and doesn't specify the context. Are these roles for the upcoming campaigns, ongoing tasks, or something else?
6. Open Floor Section Is Too Open-Ended: Having an "Open Floor" as an agenda item without any structure can lead to unfocused discussions, potentially veering off-topic and wasting valuable meeting time.
7. No Mention of Required Preparatory Work: The agenda does not indicate if there's any pre-meeting preparation required from the attendees, which could result in unproductive time spent getting everyone up to speed during the meeting itself.
8. Lack of Specificity in Attendees: Simply listing "Marketing Team, Product Managers, External Consultants" without specifying the roles or contributions expected from each group can lead to confusion about who needs to be present and why.